

Preventing & Recovering from Burnout

When work drains you to the bone

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

When work drains you to the bone

Burnout isn't a weakness or a mere 'rough patch': it's deep exhaustion — physical, emotional, mental — that settles in when you've given too much, too long, without recovering.

This guide helps you recognize the signals, understand what led you there, and put supports in place to protect yourself and rebuild. It doesn't replace medical care.

Your intention

A signal of exhaustion you feel right now: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

What led you there

Burnout doesn't fall from the sky: it settles in when you give too much, too long, without recovering — often through over-investment, a sense of duty, or difficulty setting limits.

Understanding what led you there, without judging yourself, is the first step out — and to not relapse.

Example

Convinced she 'had to carry it all', Nia held on until she collapsed. Understanding her over-investment helped her rebuild differently.

My drivers of exhaustion

What pushed me to give too much? (duty, fear, meaning, recognition)

My warning signs

List your exhaustion signals (sleep, irritability, cynicism, fatigue that won't lift).

→ *My exhaustion comes from giving too much — not from weakness.*

The thoughts that exhaust

'I must handle everything', 'if I stop, it all collapses', 'resting is failing'. These thoughts stop you from easing off — until you break.

Softening them opens the right to recover.

Example

Under 'I can't stop', Marc never delegated. Testing the opposite showed the team held without him.

Exhaustion journal

Note: the 'I must...' thought · a more sustainable version.

My right to stop

Write a line: e.g. 'Resting is part of work, not against it.'

→ *Resting isn't failing — it's what lets me last.*

Existing beyond work

You aren't your output. Rebuilding means reclaiming a life beyond work: real rest, pleasures, connection, meaning that doesn't depend on your performance.

Your worth isn't measured by your productivity.

Example

Léa relearned to have evenings of her own. Slowly, energy and desire returned.

What nourishes me beyond work

List 3 things (outside work) that do you good and that you've let go.

A worth line

E.g. 'My worth isn't measured by what I produce.'

→ *I'm worth more than my output.*

Protecting & rebuilding yourself

Recovering from burnout (and avoiding it) means acting on the environment: lighten the load, set limits, lean on supports (doctor, therapist, loved ones, HR), and sometimes stop to truly recover.

You don't have to face this alone — it's even ill-advised.

Example

With her doctor's help and a negotiated lighter load, Sofia rebuilt herself in stages.

My lightening plan

Note: 1 load to delegate/postpone · 1 limit to set · 1 support to activate (doctor, loved one).

My recovery supports

List your supports (sleep, movement, professional help) and schedule them.

→ *Protecting myself and asking for help is the path to rebuilding.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Spot the signals early: exhaustion that won't lift, cynicism, poor sleep, loss of meaning.
- Talk to a doctor / psychologist: burnout is a health matter, not willpower.
- Set limits: hours, notifications off, real breaks.
- Lighten the load with your manager/HR: it's their responsibility too.
- Don't isolate: talk to loved ones, don't carry this alone.
- Recover for real: sleep, gentle movement, screen-free time.

To fill in

My signals & loads

Warning sign	Level /10	What I can lighten

My supports

Support	Next action

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand what led me here.

Week 2 — Ease the thoughts that exhaust.

Week 3 — Exist beyond work.

Week 4 — Protect myself & build support.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The load I lighten:
- The limit I set:
- The support I activate:

TO CLOSE

Rebuilding is possible — supported, not alone.

Gently, and supported. You don't have to carry it all.

Burnout is a health matter. This guide is a psychoeducation and coaching tool, not medical advice or a substitute for care. If you recognize yourself in the exhaustion, please see a doctor or psychologist. If you're going through a very hard time, you're not alone: reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.